

First steps after an autism diagnosis

A diagnosis can bring relief, worry and a long list of unfamiliar names all at once. You don't have to do everything this week. These six steps, taken in order, will get support moving for your child in California.

- 1** **Get the written report**
Ask the clinician who diagnosed your child for the full written evaluation, not just the diagnosis code. Agencies, schools and health plans will ask for it.
- 2** **Contact your regional center**
California's 21 regional centers coordinate state-funded developmental services, and Los Angeles County has seven. If your child is under 3, ask about the Early Start program. If your child is 3 or older, ask for an intake for services. You can call yourself; you don't need a referral.
- 3** **Call your health plan about Behavioral Health Treatment**
Ask whether your plan covers Behavioral Health Treatment (BHT), which includes ABA. Many California health plans are required to cover it, and Medi-Cal covers it for members under 21 when it is medically necessary. Ask what you need to start, such as a referral or prior authorization.
- 4** **Ask your school district for an evaluation**
From age 3, your public school district is responsible for special education. Put your request for a special education evaluation in writing, date it, and keep a copy.
- 5** **Start a family folder**
Keep every report, letter, plan and phone note in one place, on paper or digitally. It will save you hours later.
- 6** **Find your people**
Connect with other parents, a local support group or Autism Kin. You'll learn faster from families who have walked the same path.

What to keep in your family folder

- Your child's diagnosis report and any other evaluations
- Insurance cards and authorization letters
- Regional center letters and your service plan (IFSP or IPP)
- School requests, assessment plans and IEP documents
- A simple log: the date, who you spoke with and what was decided

Questions about any step? Email info@autismkin.com.